Virna Vidal-Menezes

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FIELDS OF INTEREST

Development Economics, Labor Economics, and Economics of Education.

EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame, South Bend, Indiana
PhD in Economics — May 2027
MA in Economics — 2022

Federal University of Ceara, Fortaleza, CE, Brazil
MA in Economics — 2020
BA in Economics, *Magna Cum Laude* — 2017

JOB MARKET PAPER

"Looking Ahead? The Role of Future Educational Opportunities on Pre-College Human Capital"

Abstract: How do future schooling opportunities shape early educational decisions? In this paper, I exploit a large expansion in the supply of free higher education institutions (HEIs) in Brazil to analyze the role of tertiary education opportunities in increasing demand for secondary schooling in low- and middle-income countries (LMICs). To understand when higher education expansion can increase pre-tertiary attainment, I develop a simple framework that highlights the channels of impact and necessary conditions for downstream effects to occur. I construct a novel dataset on HEI roll-out and combine it with rich administrative data to estimate the effect of receiving an HEI on local public-school students' secondary schooling persistence in a staggered difference-in-differences design. Following the opening of a new campus, dropout rates among high school students fall by 1 percentage point (a 5–6% drop from the baseline mean). As a result, students in treated municipalities are also 2% more likely to graduate from high school, which corresponds to over 20,000 additional high school graduates in the first three exposed cohorts. I show that these effects are driven by increased access to higher education rather than by local labor market changes, with local students' enrollment in federal HEIs increasing by 140% following the policy. As the framework predicts, the college premium is key to generating downstream effects: changes in high school graduation are positive only in municipalities with a high pre-policy college premium, and largest where the college premium is high and the high school premium is low. Expanding access to higher education in contexts where returns to education are highly convex can be a powerful tool for improving early educational attainment, especially in LMIC settings where stand-alone returns to high school are not enough to keep students in school.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

University of Notre Dame — South Bend, Indiana
Research Assistant to Professor Taryn Dinkelman — August 2022 – May 2026

Inter-American Development Bank — Washington, D.C.
Consultant Intern at the Research Department — June 2024 – August 2024

University of Virginia and University of Notre Dame — Kampala, Uganda
Survey Field Coordinator — May 2023 – July 2023

Research Institute for Technology and Innovation - IPTI — Aracaju, SE, Brazil
Impact Evaluation Researcher — February 2021 – July 2021

Federal University of Ceara — Fortaleza, CE, Brazil
Research Assistant to Professor Guilherme Diniz Irffi — August 2019 – July 2021

SELECTED WORK IN PROGRESS

"Schooling, Jobs, Political Attitudes and Actions: Evidence from Free Primary Education Policies in Africa" with Taryn Dinkelman

"Determinants of Free Primary Education Laws and Policies in Africa: A new dataset" with Taryn Dinkelman and Amadou Jawo

"The Comprehensive Impacts of a National Inclusion Policy for Students with Disabilities" with Angelo dos Santos and Ramon Lima Ribeiro

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics — South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Principles of Microeconomics. Course Evaluation: 5/5. — Summer 2026

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics — South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Introduction to Linear Regression. Course Evaluation: 5/5. — Fall 2024

University of Notre Dame, Department of Economics — South Bend, Indiana
Instructor, Undergraduate Development Data Stata Bootcamp. — Summer 2024

Getulio Vargas Foundation (FGV), School of Public Policy and Government — Brasilia, DF, Brazil
Teaching Assistant, Graduate Causal Inference for Public Policy. — Fall 2020

GRANTS AND HONORS

National Academy of Education (NAEd) and Spencer Foundation — Washington, D.C.
NAEd/Spencer Dissertation Fellowship — September 2026 – Present

Kellogg Institute for International Studies — South Bend, Indiana
Kellogg Graduate Research Grant — January 2026

Arnold Ventures — San Francisco, California
Grant to attend the "Differences-in-Differences Causal Inference Workshop" — November 2024

AFFILIATIONS

Building Inclusive Growth (BIG) Lab — South Bend, Indiana
BIG Lab Doctoral Student Affiliate — May 2023 – Present

Kellogg Institute for International Studies — South Bend, Indiana
Kellogg Doctoral Student Affiliate — February 2023 – Present

Notre Dame Program for Interdisciplinary Educational Research (PIER) — South Bend, Indiana
Notre Dame Burns Fellow — August 2021 – Present

SERVICE AND PROFESSIONAL TRAINING

Referee: *Journal of Human Resources*

Office of Grants and Fellowships, University of Notre Dame — South Bend, Indiana
Speaker on Grant and Fellowship Winners Panel — August 2026

Department of Economics, University of Notre Dame — South Bend, Indiana
Graduate Student Committee Co-chair — August 2023 – May 2024

Getulio Vargas Foundation (FGV) and Itau Social — Sao Paulo, SP, Brazil
Advanced Summer Course in Public Policy and Social Projects Evaluation — January 2020 – March 2020

PRESENTATIONS

2026 Midwest International Economic Development Conference (MWIEDC), MidSouth Education Policy Workshop, Midwest Economics of Education.
2025 Association for Public Policy and Analysis (APPAM) Fall Conference.
2024 Southern Economic Association (SEA) 94th Annual Meeting.

SKILLS AND PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- **Technical Skills:** Stata, Matlab, R, SurveyCTO, LaTeX.
- **Language Skills:** Portuguese (native), English (fluent), French (advanced), and Spanish (advanced).
- **Professional Memberships:** Association for Public Policy and Analysis (APPAM), American Economic Association (AEA), Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP), American Educational Research Association (AERA), Society for Research on Educational Effectiveness (SREE).

REFERENCES

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